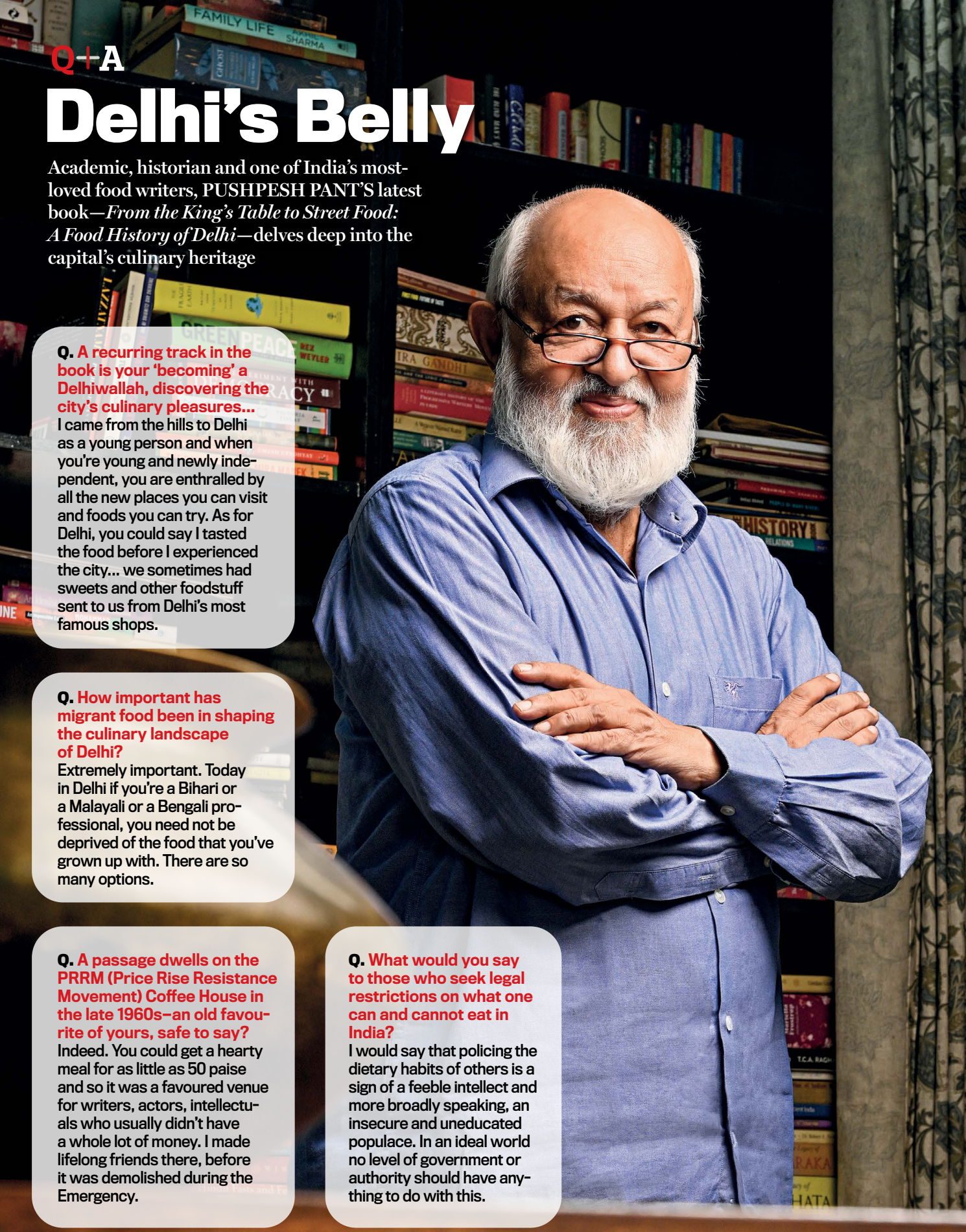
Q+A

Delhi's Belly

Academic, historian and one of India's most-loved food writers, PUSHPESH PANT'S latest book—*From the King's Table to Street Food: A Food History of Delhi*—delves deep into the capital's culinary heritage



Q. A recurring track in the book is your 'becoming' a Delhiwallah, discovering the city's culinary pleasures...
I came from the hills to Delhi as a young person and when you're young and newly independent, you are enthralled by all the new places you can visit and foods you can try. As for Delhi, you could say I tasted the food before I experienced the city... we sometimes had sweets and other foodstuff sent to us from Delhi's most famous shops.

Q. How important has migrant food been in shaping the culinary landscape of Delhi?
Extremely important. Today in Delhi if you're a Bihari or a Malayali or a Bengali professional, you need not be deprived of the food that you've grown up with. There are so many options.

Q. A passage dwells on the PRRM (Price Rise Resistance Movement) Coffee House in the late 1960s—an old favourite of yours, safe to say?
Indeed. You could get a hearty meal for as little as 50 paise and so it was a favoured venue for writers, actors, intellectuals who usually didn't have a whole lot of money. I made lifelong friends there, before it was demolished during the Emergency.

Q. What would you say to those who seek legal restrictions on what one can and cannot eat in India?
I would say that policing the dietary habits of others is a sign of a feeble intellect and more broadly speaking, an insecure and uneducated populace. In an ideal world no level of government or authority should have anything to do with this.

Photograph by RAJWANT RAWAT

–with Aditya Mani Jha